

Cesar Garcia

Founding Designer · Lead Product Designer · Senior IC

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Lisbon, Portugal · Remote across Europe · Portuguese (EU) citizen

SUMMARY

Twice a founding designer, an engineer by training, AI-native end to end: design, building, shipping. I turn high-stakes technical constraints into proven, unique, simple solutions, tuned to human behavior. 200M+ users across payments, pensions, crypto, financial crime, consumer and SaaS.

SKILLS

Design Design systems, Product strategy, User research, Prototyping, Information architecture, Design leadership and hiring, Data-led design, iOS, Android and web

Domains Payments, Cryptocurrency and Web3, Digital wallets, KYC / AML, Financial crime compliance, Pensions, AI products

Tools Figma, Claude Code, OpenAI Codex, AI-assisted prototyping and engineering

EXPERIENCE

Selected case studies at cesarxdesign.com ↗

Product Design Lead, Confirмо (Sep 2025 - Jul 2026) ↗

First designer at a crypto payments processor moving \$750M a year. Owned the buyer-and-merchant surface plus brand and website, built the component library and design system from scratch, and moved design to the front of product development with the CPO. Redesigned a checkout stuck at 9%, tripling success to 27%, and 43% in key markets at almost twice the industry average, adding \$135M in converted payments.

Ran a full audit of the checkout: mapped every screen by hand, cross-read support complaints against usage data, and ran workshops with sales, engineering and product to find a \$680M a year drop-off that analytics could not see across only three steps. Traced it to the invoice trigger rather than the interface, restructured the selection so customers could compare and preview before committing to anything irreversible, and rebuilt the flow around a single anchor carrying the payment to completion. Shipped against live traffic, iterating on real signal.

Launched Confirмо Subscriptions with Circle and Solana, the first recurring crypto payments product of its kind, built on smart contracts and designed with AI from day one, frontend and backend. Their success moved Confirмо to API-only enterprise clients.

Founder, DONE (Side venture, Mar 2018 - Mar 2020 and May 2024 - Present) ↗

Co-founded a consumer iOS fitness app and ran product and design across two engineers and a trainer, owning it from concept to launch. Shipped March 2020 to a 5.0 App Store rating, then every gym on earth went on lockdown. Timing: immaculate.

Ran research sessions in the gym, working out alongside testers and taking feedback live. Iterated across multiple versions, and worked through technical constraints with the developers, reshaping designs to accommodate engineering's limited capacity. Picked it up again in 2024, and again in the current build, designing and engineering it solo with AI. Ships to the App Store in 2026.

Lead Product Designer, Trust Wallet (Apr 2025 - Sep 2025)

Joined the banking and fiat squad, bridging traditional money and crypto, leading the effort to grow the fiat-native share of its 200M users. Scoped to fiat transactions, I argued onboarding was fundamental to that growth, widening our remit.

Audited onboarding screen by screen, reducing six import methods to a single routed decision. Drew on my engineering background to design a flow that adapts to the user, reading the wallet type from what they paste instead of asking them to name it, a distinction the software could make and a newcomer could not. Overhauled the fiat-to-crypto funding flow too.

Staff Product Designer, BLKBOX.ai (Mar 2024 - Mar 2025)

Ran design at an AI platform that generates ad creative and tests it in small live bets across markets. Put budget definition in the client's hands and let the product run the bets itself, opening it to the NFL for market-specific Super Bowl ads.

Delivered a full UX audit and user interviews, mentoring another designer through it. Encoded advertising craft into the generation engine as guardrails, teaching it how an ad should execute. Built the controls that made it self-serve and self-correcting.

Head of Design and Product Owner, Mara (Nov 2022 - Feb 2024) ↗

Managed a team of four designers at a crypto and fiat wallet for African markets, backed by Coinbase, later adding engineering and customer support responsibilities. Delivered a full product redesign in under a month, information architecture, user flows and a new design system, shipping to 24M users. Signup completion rose from 12% to 88%, adding 20M users and saving \$6.9M a year. Overhauled onboarding, from 27 screens to an essential 8. Funnel analysis across 50,000 daily signups found seven major drop-offs, KYC the biggest. Moved it into transactions, cutting third-party spend by \$5.7M.

Rebuilt the six primary flows, standardising them on one interaction pattern, replacing a bloated library and freeing engineering capacity. Presented roadmap and growth strategy to the investor group. Acquisition ran at 2.1M new users a month after launch.

Founding Designer, Cable (Jul 2020 - Oct 2022) ↗

Sole designer at a financial crime and AML compliance startup, the only one with a live product. Shifted decisions from reactive client specs to informed design, and transformed a pre-revenue pilot into a paid suite with two flagship features.

Ran weekly research sessions with pilot users, designing to outcomes rather than transcribed workflows. Restructured the product architecture around its record of accounts, reviewers and decisions, with a dedicated home, a familiar card model, and an account ID list that became the most used component in the suite. Worked with engineering to sequence the roadmap by dependency, turning it into a predictable delivery runway.

Built Oversight as a second flagship, giving sponsor banks the same controls over the fintechs on their charter through one interface with different data. Rebuilt the interface foundation when that work outgrew it, stripping out the navigation the whole structure hung on and redesigning every screen against the new model. Landed the product's first paid sale on the back of it, turning the free pilot partner into a paying client. Cable went on to 50+ banks and fintechs, and was later acquired by Synctera.

Founding Designer, Penfold (Jun 2019 - May 2020) ↗

First hire on a 4-person team in a UK digital pension. Turned the proof of concept into a live product in seven days, acquiring our first customers in time for the next funding round. Year one closed at 3,000 savers and £4M under management.

Created a research loop that fed the roadmap: session replays every morning, a customer support meeting every Friday, and a beta programme recruiting from both. It showed customers quitting midway through a linear signup, and pushed mobile to the top of the roadmap. Restructured onboarding into five modules customers could leave and resume, turning users who quit into users who finished later. Built one design system serving desktop and mobile, halving engineering load and letting us ship daily.

Refocused the product away from first-time savers and onto users with existing pensions, rebuilding it around combining the pots they already held rather than opening empty accounts, reducing acquisition costs. Signups went from 100 to 600 a month, each arriving with a pot to transfer. The foundation held: Penfold now manages over £1B and was voted Best Pension 2026.

Head of Product Design, Starcount (Dec 2015 - May 2019) ↗

Hired as Senior Product Designer, the company's first, and promoted to Head of Product Design on the strength of the product work, growing the function to five and managing four designers. Turned three consultancy-only datasets into a self-serve product that hit its £1M first-year revenue target in 91 days, across two product lines launched from scratch and one revived.

Redesigned the company's only product and launched a second on postcode delivery data, landing Twitter's first-ever data deal and Royal Mail on the back of both. Ran discovery across data, engineering, sales and direct client interviews to shape the combined product: a live map of UK demand covering 1.7M postcodes and 27M households, refreshed by 20M UK tweets a day.

Rebalanced the projection with the data team so the map showed demand rather than population, after an accurate one put 90% of the visibility on London: technically wrong, like a subway map, and the only version anyone could act on. Repurposed 3D extrusion from a mapping convention into a predictor of where demand was heading. Ran the prototype as the sales deck, growing the prospect list before launch.

Designer, Leo Burnett (Sep 2013 - Oct 2015)

Designed across the Apple, Samsung, Mercedes and Vodafone accounts at an advertising agency, and led the complete visual rebrand of Lisbon's commuter rail network. Mentored incoming design interns.

Software Engineer, Pfizer (Jun 2006 - Dec 2012)

Delivered a CRM migration with Accenture in the UK, managing the outsourced team against the Portugal specification. Designed an internal helpdesk tool later adopted across European branches.

EDUCATION

FLAG Design Academy (2012 - 2013) · Instituto Superior Técnico, Computer Science (2003 - 2006)